

real idea of this country if he had not wandered through the frozen glaciers of its legal system. If he had not befriended a frisky penguin and been shown some chilling X-rays of the grand body of Indian law and order and justice.

Outside the gates of the courts ran the wide stately roads of Lutyens' Delhi, curving with an imperial assurance around the imposing edifices of the National Stadium, the National Gallery of Modern Art and the India Gate, then taking the high road to Raisina Hill where the monoliths of North and South Block continued to be metaphors for the imperiousness and inscrutability of the state, before finishing up inside the excessive sprawl of the presidential palace,



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an appropriate metaphor of shallow decorativeness. Patrolled by police jeeps, these were ceremonial roads, cocooning a space where the state could continually convince itself of its power and purpose. Any dwarf wearing the ensemble of the state could bring the tallest citizen of the country to his knees.

But inside the high gates of the courts, the splendour of the state was in disarray. From the moment you entered the grounds you battled your way through parked scooters and bikes and cars, weaving through thick clusters of petitioners, penguins, policemen—weirdly, holding hands with their criminal wards as lovers would, since the Supreme Court had banned the handcuffing of small-time offenders. Everywhere was dirt and offal and loud voices, and random chain-

link fences you had to hop over. The hum all around was of transactions. A brisk bazaar, where you could strike any deal you wanted as long as your attitude was unburdened and your wallet thick. Going around to the back of the building to meet my lawyer, I saw advocates' kiosks that looked more like they dealt in minor merchandise—cigarettes, paan, biscuits, candy—than in the sombre questions of law.

Inside the once opulent building built during the Raj to serve as the Delhi outpost of the royal house of Patiala, the state's glory was equally in tatters. The sweeping staircases, the marble floors, the teak balustrades, the carved windows, the fluted ceilings, all were in distress. Everything was soiled, dirty, peeling. Every corner had a chiaroscuro of blood-red paan stains. Despite their grand scale, the corridors were dark and musty and poorly lit, with the illumination from the windows and ventilators truncated by dirt and furniture. The windows were further obscured by human bodies—sitting, standing, trying to wedge their way through. Many of these were clearly peasants, their faces unshaven and gaunt, their thick blankets and bodies giving off the rank odour of animals and sweat. I had to put out my hands and literally push people aside to make way for us. My shadows did the same, their elbows jutting out. At one point, just when I was beginning to enjoy shoving the idiots around, Sara poked me in my ass, warning me angrily to take it easy. When I went to take a leak in the makeshift urinal under the staircase, I had to pay a rupee for the privilege and survive such a stench of fresh piss as could have deterred the stoutest litigant.

The fear of the law clearly unloosed the bladder.

In this hellhole, we were led by my penguin into a high-ceilinged room that was no less nondescript and soiled. It was bursting with a silent clamour, as routine mayhem tried to rein itself in, in deference to the setting. The milling bodies moved around the ugly wooden cupboards littered all over, in random array, filled to oozing with dusty files. These were all tied in strings of different colours, and had dirty ears of paper peeping out. Each time an attendant opened a cupboard the files began to topple out, and had to be desperately held in check with one hand even as the right one was located and extracted. As at the dera on the night of the metamorphosis, there was only one point of calm in this melee: the elevated platform at the end of the room where, behind a wide wooden desk, sat a clerkly-looking man in black-rimmed spectacles. ■